Lesson 23: Outlining

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.3: Outlining.

In this lesson

You will learn how to put your ideas in an order that fits your purpose (chronological order, spatial order or order of importance) and how to set out a formal outline, both as a topic outline and as a sentence outline. You will outline the model essay on stereotype threat from Lesson 20 and then outline your own Unit 3 essay. Many university instructors ask for an outline before a major paper, and a good outline makes the drafting in Lessons 24 to 26 much easier.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose chronological order, spatial order or order of importance to fit a purpose.
- Format a formal outline with the thesis at the top, Roman numerals, capital letters and Arabic numerals.
- Write a topic outline with parallel headings, and turn it into a sentence outline.
- Test an outline with the book's checklist.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
outline	a written plan that serves as a skeleton for the paragraphs you write	Later you will add "flesh" and "muscle" to the skeleton.
informal outline	a short list of key ideas in the order you will present them	for an essay question on a test or a brief oral presentation
formal outline	a detailed guide that shows how all your supporting ideas relate to each other	Many instructors require one before a major paper.
topic outline	a formal outline written in words and phrases	II. A balanced treatment of criticism
sentence outline	a formal outline written in complete sentences	II. The authors address criticism of the research.
chronological order	order in time	to explain the steps in a process
spatial order	order in space	to help readers visualize something
order of importance	order by importance, benefit or significance	to persuade or convince

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
main point	an idea that develops the thesis; it becomes the topic sentence of a body paragraph	I, II, III
supporting detail / subpoint	a part of a main point / an example or specific inside a supporting detail	A, B, C / 1, 2, 3
Roman numerals	the letters used as numbers: I, II, III, IV, V	Use Roman numerals for main points.
parallel structure	the same grammatical form for items at the same level (see Lesson 5)	All the headings must be written in parallel structure.
preliminary	early, not yet final	a working, or preliminary, thesis statement

Rules and explanations

Order and purpose

Order is your choice of what to present first, second, third and so on. In some courses your assignments are your only direct contact with your instructor, so a well-ordered paper makes a good impression. Choose the order that best fits your purpose (to inform, to explain, to persuade, or a combination):

Order	Purpose
Chronological order	to explain the history of an event or a topic; to tell a story or relate an experience; to explain how to do or make something; to explain the steps in a process
Spatial order	to help readers visualize something as you want them to see it; to create a main impression using the senses (sight, touch, taste, smell and sound)
Order of importance	to persuade or convince; to rank items by their importance, benefit or significance

A longer paper may use different orders in different parts.

Informal and formal outlines

- An **informal outline** is a short list of key ideas in order. It keeps you focused in a stressful situation, such as an essay question on a test.
- A **formal outline** is a detailed guide for a longer assignment. It shows which ideas are of equal importance and which are of lesser importance. If you must submit it with your final draft, revise it to match the changes you made while writing.

The format of a formal outline

- Put your **thesis** (not your introduction) at the top.
- Use **Roman numerals** (I, II, III) for the main points that develop the thesis.

- Use **capital letters** (A, B, C) to divide main points into parts.
- Use **Arabic numerals** (1, 2, 3) to divide an A, B or C into smaller parts: the examples and specifics.
- **Never divide a point into only one part:** for every I there must be a II, for every A a B, and for every 1 a 2.
- Use indentation to show how the ideas are related. The outline may end with suggestions for the concluding paragraph.

``` Thesis statement I. Main point 1 -> topic sentence of body paragraph 1 A. Supporting detail -> support sentence of body paragraph 1

    1. Subpoint
    2. Subpoint

B. Supporting detail C. Supporting detail II. Main point 2 -> topic sentence of body paragraph 2 A. Supporting detail B. Supporting detail III. Main point 3 -> topic sentence of body paragraph 3 A. Supporting detail B. Supporting detail ```

Note: in the lesson material, the main points of the skeleton appear as "1., 2., 3." because of the web page's formatting. In a formal outline, write I, II, III.

### Topic outlines and sentence outlines

Both types use the same format. A **topic outline** uses words or phrases, which keep it short and easy to understand; all its headings must be in **parallel structure** (for example, all noun phrases). A **sentence outline** uses complete sentences, which can later become your topic sentences and supporting sentences.

### Checklist for an effective topic outline

- Do I have a controlling idea that guides the development of the entire piece of writing?
- Do I have three or more main points that I want to make? Does each main point connect to my controlling idea?
- Is my outline in the best order (chronological order, spatial order or order of importance) for me to present my main points?
- Do I have supporting details that will help me inform, explain or prove my main points?
- Do I need to add more support? If so, where?
- Do I need to make any adjustments in my working thesis statement before I consider it the final version?

## Practice

**Exercise 1. Order and purpose.** Which order (chronological, spatial or order of importance) fits each purpose?

1. To persuade or convince
2. To explain the steps in a process
```

3. To help readers visualize something as you want them to see it
4. To rank items by their importance, benefit, or significance
5. To tell a story or relate an experience
6. To create a main impression using the senses
7. To explain the history of an event or a topic
8. To explain how to do or make something

Exercise 2. Outline format. Complete the rules from the lesson material.

1. Place your _____ (not your introduction) at the top of the outline page.
2. Use _____ (I, II, III, IV, V, etc.) to identify main points that develop the thesis statement.
3. Use _____ (A, B, C, D, etc.) to divide your main points into parts.
4. Use _____ (1, 2, 3, 4, 5, etc.) if you need to subdivide any As, Bs, or Cs into smaller parts.
5. For every roman numeral I, there must be a _____. For every A, there must be a _____.
6. A topic outline uses _____ instead of complete sentences.
7. In a topic outline, all the headings must be written in _____.
8. Each main point becomes the _____ of a body paragraph.

Exercise 3. Outline a model essay. Use the student essay on stereotype threat from Lesson 20's material. Write a topic outline of the essay: the thesis at the top, the three body paragraphs as I, II and III, and their supporting details as A, B, C (and 1, 2 where needed). Keep the headings parallel. Which order does the essay use?

Exercise 4. From topic outline to sentence outline. Rewrite section I of your Exercise 3 outline as a sentence outline.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Check the format: thesis at the top, Roman numerals, capital letters, Arabic numerals, and no point divided into only one part."
- "Are the headings in my topic outline parallel? Rewrite any that are not and explain why."
- "Ask me the six questions of the outline checklist one at a time about my outline."
- "Which order does my outline use: chronological, spatial or order of importance? Does it fit my purpose? Suggest a better order if there is one."
- "For each main point in my outline, ask me what evidence I will use. Tell me where I need more support."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. An outline is a written plan | that serves as a skeleton | for the paragraphs you write.
2. Choose the order | that will most effectively fit your purpose | and support your main point.

3. Place your thesis, | not your introduction, | at the top of the outline page.
4. For every roman numeral I, | there must be a II.
5. Words and phrases keep the outline short | and easier to comprehend.
6. Word stress: OUT·line, chro·no·LOG·i·cal, SPA·tial, im·POR·tance, PAR·al·lel, NU·mer·al.

Writing task

A formal outline of your Unit 3 essay (about one page). Use the narrowed topic from Lesson 21 and the revised working thesis from Lesson 22 (for example, on stereotype threat and how schools can reduce it, stress and coping in first-year students, or sleep and memory).

1. Write your thesis at the top.
2. Choose an order (chronological, spatial or order of importance) and note why it fits your purpose.
3. Write a topic outline with three main points (I, II, III). Give each main point at least two supporting details (A, B), and add subpoints (1, 2) for examples and specifics. Note where each piece of evidence will come from (for psychology: the reading in Lesson 20, the OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e*, or articles from Google Scholar or PubMed Central).
4. End with a suggestion for your concluding paragraph.
5. Rewrite your three main points as complete sentences: these are the topic sentences of your body paragraphs.

Self-editing checklist

- My thesis, not my introduction, is at the top, and every main point connects to it.
- I have three main points in the best order for my purpose.
- The format is correct: I, II, III; A, B, C; 1, 2, 3, with indentation.
- No point is divided into only one part.
- The headings at each level are parallel.
- Each main point has enough supporting details, and I know where more support is needed.
- I adjusted my working thesis if the outline changed my ideas.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Order of importance
2. Chronological order
3. Spatial order
4. Order of importance
5. Chronological order
6. Spatial order
7. Chronological order
8. Chronological order

Exercise 2

1. thesis
2. Roman numerals
3. capital letters
4. Arabic numerals
5. II; B
6. words or phrases
7. parallel structure
8. topic sentence

Exercise 3 (example answer)

``` Thesis: Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences. I. An engaging and understandable presentation A. Personal questions at the start B. A conversational tone

    1. Use of the second person
    2. An example: "As you may have gathered ..."

C. Paraphrases and summaries instead of direct quotations II. A balanced treatment of criticism A. The early criticism: lab studies, not natural settings B. The response: naturalistic research confirming the lab studies C. The result: a rounded view and greater credibility III. A personal connection A. The chapter's point about feedback and negative stereotypes B. The writer's freshman math class

    1. No questions in class
    2. Worse test results

C. A new understanding of her poor performance Conclusion: the three points restated; steps to lessen stereotype threat ```
```

The headings at each level are noun phrases (parallel structure). The essay follows the order of the three parts of its thesis. Of the book's three methods, it is closest to order of importance, because its purpose is to persuade; it ends with its most personal point.

Exercise 4 (example answer) ``` I. McRaney and her colleagues present many academic studies in a way that is interesting and understandable to readers without a specialized background. A. They begin the chapter with personal questions that prepare readers for the content. B. They use a conversational tone that makes readers feel the authors are talking to them directly.

1. They address readers in the second person.
2. One sentence begins, "As you may have gathered ..."

C. They paraphrase and summarize the studies instead of quoting specialized academic language. ```

My notes